would isolate India internationally, and indifference towards the Mujahideen would distance India from the Afghan people. Having worked closely with the Janata Party on its foreign policy agenda of 'genuine non-alignment' (despite being close to Gandhi during the Emergency), Mehta firmly believed that only a conciliatory and non-aligned policy (one that would allow India and Pakistan to rationalise bilateral relations) could prevent a negative spillover of the Soviet actions in the region.[63]

Not surprisingly, Gandhi's domestic opponents severely criticised her decision on various counts such as, (a) India had not stood by its principle of non-alignment and alienated itself among the Third World, (b) India did not show any respect for the sovereignty of a smaller friendly neighbour such as Afghanistan, (c) India did not criticise Moscow effectively in the light of these concerns, and, (d) the ambiguity around the idea of a 'political solution'—as Gandhi actively advocated—gave Moscow breathing space to continue with its military presence in Afghanistan, which would not end anytime soon. Rao and Congress (I) MP Devendra Nath Dwivedi, a renowned lawyer who hailed from Varanasi, tried defending their policy in security terms, i.e. the threat from Pakistan, China and the US.[64] The counter-attack, led by Dinesh Goswami from Assam and BJP leader Jagdish Prasad Mathur from Uttar Pradesh (UP), however, was fearsome. By emphasising national security, and believing the false claim that the Soviet Union would not remain in Afghanistan a day longer than required, the ruling government was fooling itself, argued Mathur. Indeed, Soviet ambassador to Afghanistan, Tabeev, had communicated Moscow's intentions 'to stay' in Afghanistan to Dixit in 1982.[65] According to Goswami, the government's approach was 'ambivalent' at best, and had compromised upon the key issue of Afghan sovereignty.[66] A major part of the Afghan people's opinion, which was allegedly against the intervention, was also not respected.

Manubhai Patel, a veteran Congress leader and Gandhian hailing from Gujarat, in a statement filled with irony, lauded the government for openly criticising Moscow's intervention in Afghanistan after its initial 'confused' reaction, but wondered if the government had

> compromised its attitude on the sovereignty of a country, whatever policy it might have, that an outside country could just go into such a country and threaten the sovereignty of a particular small country